

The Best Places to Eat Rijsttafel

Blue Pepper expensive

Amsterdam's Blue Pepper adds *haute* modern touches to the abundance of *rijsttafel*. Executive chef Sonja Pereira's interpretation of classic *rijsttafel* keeps the number of dishes down while adding flavors to maintain diversity of taste. Zesty additions to the traditional array include salads such as *salada asinan segar* (crab, mango, and pineapple with tamarind) and *salada bebek* (roasted duck with green turmeric leaves), while clever reinventions include grilled fish pâté in place of dried fish, or lime and soy replacing peanuts in a lamb satay sauce. Dutch shrimp adds a local presence to spicy green beans.

A more contemporary influence permeates the alternative Indonesian menu overseen by Pereira's colleague Tani Morabe. Shaped by modern Indonesia's vibrant culinary interactions with its Southeastern Asian neighbors, spicy chicken soup mingles with glass noodles and floating quail eggs, while grated coconut gives an East Indies tinge to wok-fried vegetables. "Indonesian cooking at its summit," raved one Dutch critic, and many would agree.

**Nassaukade 366, Amsterdam; open 6–10 PM
Wed–Mon; www.restaurantbluepepper.com**

Also in Amsterdam

In the Eastern Canal district, restaurants line Utrechtsestraat, including the **Tempo Doeloe** (www.tempodoeloerestaurant.nl; *moderate*), a well-regarded eatery that offers an air of restrained privacy along with attention to detail. It serves three different sizes of *rijsttafel*, from 15 to 25 dishes. Those on a budget should head for **Bojo** (www.bojo.nl; *inexpensive*) on Lange Leidsedwardsstraat, where huge portions don't mean compromising on quality, and the late hours make it a boon for night owls.

Also in the Netherlands

In The Hague, two places stand out: **Garoeda** (www.garoeda.nl; *moderate*), which was opened by Indonesians resettling after independence in 1949; and **Raffles** (www.restaurantraffles.com; *expensive*), which sits amid Archipel's beautiful streets and boasts an interior based on the Javan house of the owner's grandparents.

Around the World

The opulent **Oasis Restaurant** (www.oasis-restaurant.co.id; *expensive*) in Jakarta is one of the few places in Indonesia that now serves *rijsttafel*. This two-story mansion was built in 1928 as the private home of Dutch millionaire F. Brandenburg van Oltse – who, in true colonial style, made his fortune from plantations of tea, rubber, and cinchona (a quinine-rich tree). Enjoy your "rice feast" here in grand style, served by up to 15 wait staff.



Above Modern Dutch restaurants, such as Amsterdam's Blue Pepper (pictured), offer innovative versions of classic Indonesian dishes

Left *Rijsttafel* today consists of 12–30 dishes; in the 1920s the Hotel des Indes in Batavia (now northern Jakarta) served 60 different dishes